

How to Get Shredded by Christmas (Do These 3 Things)

Channel: Brandon Carter · Published: Sep 06, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5sHUnw1gi-w> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Brandon Carter lays out a no-nonsense 16-week holiday shred plan: aggressive calorie deficit, high protein, 20,000 daily steps, and 3–4 weekly full-body lifting sessions — while avoiding the psychological traps of holiday overeating.

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🎃 The Mediocre Marathon — Why the Holidays Destroy Your Physique 0:26

- Brandon calls the Halloween-through-Christmas stretch "**the mediocre marathon**" — the most dangerous time for the American male physique
- The three stages of the mediocre marathon:
 - **Halloween** — starts as a kids' holiday but ends with a 38-year-old man eating fun-sized Reese's and Snickers over the sink at midnight; leftover candy bags stick around and get eaten through November
 - **Thanksgiving** — culturally frames overeating as a family value; the real damage is eating leftovers for an entire week afterward
 - **December** — holiday office parties with open bars and mini crab cakes, followed back-to-back Christmas meals at mom's house, then a partner's family
- The average American gains roughly **15 pounds** over the holidays
- The opportunity: Christmas is **16 weeks away**, which is enough time to lose 16–32 lbs of fat
 - Losing **1 lb/week** = 16 lbs lighter by Christmas
 - Losing **2 lbs/week** = 32 bs lighter by Christmas

Rule 1: Control Your Diet with an Aggressive Calorie & Protein Target 2:23

- **Calorie formula:** bodyweight in pounds $\times$ 10 = daily calorie target
 - Example: 200 lb person $\rightarrow$ 2,000 calories/day
 - Use *current* bodyweight, NOT goal bodyweight
- Why a deep deficit rather than the common 500- or 200-calorie deficit:
 - A 200-calorie deficit is wiped out easily — condiments and sauces alone can add 200 calories
 - The FDA allows food labels to be off by **up to 20% in either direction**, so a food labeled 500 calories could actually be 600 calories
 - If label inaccuracies happen multiple times per day, a small deficit is completely erased
- **Protein formula:** 1 gram of protein per pound of *current* bodyweight per day
 - Again, current bodyweight — not goal bodyweight
- Why not use goal bodyweight for protein (as some influencers suggest):
 - High protein serves a different purpose here than muscle-building studies address — it's about *preserving muscle* during a deep caloric deficit
 - A caloric deficit is catabolic (breaks down muscle); keeping protein high mitigates that catabolism
 - The deeper the deficit, the higher protein should be
- Brandon's credentials: certified nutritionist, 27 years of training, coached thousands of people

Why Protein Is a Cheat Code (Thermogenic Effect) 5:25

- **Thermic effect of food (TEF):** your body burns calories just to digest food; the rate differs by macronutrient

Macronutrient	Calories burned during digestion
Fat	0–3% of calories consumed
Carbohydrates	10–15% of calories consumed
Protein	20–30% of calories consumed

- Practical implication: eat 100 calories of protein $\rightarrow$ your body only *absorbs* 70–80 of those calories
- Brandon compares it to a **cashback credit card** — you get some of those calories "back"
- This is why he recommends keeping protein as high as possible regardless of the calorie math

"Protein is a cheat code. Why wouldn't we keep that the highest if we know it's kind of like a cashback card?"

- Note on muscle-building studies (e.g., Jeff Nippard): those studies recommending 0.7–0.8g/lb are about *building* muscle, not maintaining it during an aggressive cut — a different goal entirely

Rule 2: Hit 20,000 Steps Per Day 9:02

- Target: **20,000 steps per day** — Brandon says he gets comments daily from people confirming it works
- Rationale: fat didn't accumulate in 16 weeks, so losing it fast requires aggressive action
- Step breakdown to reach 20,000:
 - **Morning walk** (30 min immediately after waking) → ~3,000 steps
 - **After-lunch walk** → ~3,000 steps
 - **After-work walk** (1 hour) → ~6,000 steps
 - **Cheat code during work:** take a 10-minute walk every hour throughout the workday → ~8,000 extra steps
 - Total: 3,000 + 3,000 + 6,000 + 8,000 = **20,000 steps**
- Mindset note: "If you argue for your own limitations, you get to keep them"
- Advice for those who can't hit 20,000: "Never let what you can't do stop you from doing what you can do"
- Bonus: rest periods between sets at the gym are used to walk around and accumulate additional steps

Rule 3: Lift Weights 3–4 Times Per Week 10:59

- Format: **full-body workouts**, which Brandon has used exclusively for 11–12+ years
- Structure:
 - Pick **1–2 exercises per body part**
 - Do **3–4 sets** per exercise
 - Rest **90 seconds between sets** (uses Apple Watch voice timer: "Set 90-second timer")
 - If very winded, extend rest to **2 minutes**
- Workout duration concern: full-body does NOT mean 3 hours — timed rest keeps sessions efficient
- During rest periods: walk around the gym to accumulate more steps (ties back to the 20,000-step goal)
- **Supersets** for opposing muscle groups to accelerate fat loss:
 - Example 1: bench press → immediately into bent-over rows
 - Example 2: bicep curls → immediately into tricep extensions
 - Then take the 90-second rest
- Frequency: 3–4 sessions per week

The Psychology of Consistency — Why Cheat Days Backfire 12:34

- **"Mediocre mantras"** to watch out for (peer pressure phrases):
 - "You can just have one"
 - "One day won't hurt you"
 - "Just enjoy this"
 - "Just one drink"

- The real danger isn't the calories from one slip — it's the psychological damage:
 - Each cheat trains you to accept inconsistency; once you accept inconsistency, being consistent becomes hard
 - Cheat days **induce cravings** for the foods you cheated with in the days that follow
- Brandon's personal experience with cheat days:
 - Cheat on Sunday → cravings for that food all of Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday
 - By Thursday cravings fade → then another cheat day on Sunday and the cycle restarts
 - Once he quit cheat days **cold turkey**, all cravings disappeared
- Brandon has not had a cheat day in **~4 years**
 - Plans to bring a **food scale to Thanksgiving** — still eats the food, but tracks macros precisely
- Dopamine analogy: cheating on your diet (or your partner) works the same way — novelty spikes dopamine, then makes your baseline feel worse by contrast, creating cravings for the novelty
- Recommendation: **no alcohol, no cheat days** during the mediocre marathon (Halloween through Christmas)
- On diet type: Brandon is personally keto (11 years), but says carb approach doesn't matter — **calories and protein are the primary variables** for body composition
 - Keto personal benefits he cites: clear skin, looks younger than 43, hasn't had a cold in 11 years, never tested positive for COVID despite repeated exposure

Supplement Mention: Tirzepatide (GLP-1) 17:38

- Brandon has been on **tirzepatide ("Zepbound" / "Trappy")** for ~2 months and calls it his favorite GLP-1
- Primary benefit for cutting: dramatically suppresses appetite, making it easy to stay in a deficit
- Strong caveat: **talk to your doctor before doing anything** — only pursue it with a prescription
- Key warning for tirzepatide users: because it kills hunger, you risk *not eating enough*
 - Must still track calories to ensure you're eating at least **1g of protein per pound of bodyweight**
 - Undereating without tracking will cause muscle loss
- His take: if you've never used it and start during the mediocre marathon, "this will be the easiest cut you ever did"

How to Track Calories: Claude AI vs. MyFitnessPal 19:13

- Used **MyFitnessPal** for over a decade — no longer his recommendation
- Now tracks everything in **Claude (AI chatbot)**
 - Can talk to it conversationally about what he ate
 - Can take a **photo of food** and it estimates calories/macros automatically
- Practical use case: attends Miami Heat games (lives across the street from the arena), can't bring a food scale past bag check → takes a photo of arena food, uploads to Claude, gets an instant calorie estimate

- Workflow: start a new chat, pin it to the top, log everything there throughout the day
- A free tracking prompt is available in the video description
- Verdict: "I'm never going back to MyFitnessPal"